The Teamwork Story

Your Norwich house hunt, taken seriously. Why it cannot win on being a cool story, why it can win decisively on the reflection, and the four things in it you have not noticed.

Doc 37 · "Tell me about a time you worked in a team" · Asset Management, Client Solutions Group · Prepared 4 November 2026

1 The honest verdict first

The framework you pasted gives two routes to standing out: the **cool story**, or the **sophisticated reflection**.

> Be realistic. A student house hunt is not charity boxing or Kilimanjaro. **You will not win on route one, so stop trying.** But route two is wide open, and your story has more in it for that than you realise.

And there is a reason not to force a cool story you do not have. A candidate who stretches an ordinary experience into an adventure sounds worse than one who takes an ordinary experience seriously. The thing that reads as mature is *not* having done something dramatic. It is noticing what was actually difficult about something undramatic.

Here is the good news, and it is the point of this whole document: **your story contains a genuine coordination problem with real financial stakes, a textbook economic failure you can name by its name, and a pragmatic trade-off you actually made.** That is all three things the reflection route asks for. You just have not been describing them.

2 What is actually in your story

You told me the facts. Let me show you what is in them.

THING 1

You had no authority and no relationship

You were not the leader. You were not elected. **You had met one of the six.** The other four were strangers. You had zero social capital with most of the group and no way to compel anyone to do anything.

That is not a weakness in the story. **It is the story.** Getting people to act when you have authority is management. Getting people to act when you have none is the harder skill, and it happens to be the exact skill the job you applied for requires.

THING 2

The geography was a real constraint, not a detail

You were in London. The houses were in Norwich — roughly 115 miles away. You were arranging viewings for properties you could not see, in a city you were not in, for people who would not go.

Say the number. "I was organising it from a hundred and fifteen miles away" is concrete, specific, and nobody else's answer contains it.

THING 3

There was a hard deadline with a real cost of failing

Norwich student housing goes in a narrow window. Move slowly and you get the bad house, the bad location, or nothing. The deadline was not set by you and could not be moved.

That is a genuine Situation with genuine stakes — the thing the framework asks you to establish in the first fifteen seconds.

THING 4

You cared more than the situation warranted, and you said so

You told me: *"I appreciate that this was a second thought to some people, but this was quite important to me."*

That is the most human and most interesting sentence you have said about this, and I would not change a word of it. It answers the question behind the question — *why did you step up?* — without the cliché of "I'm a natural leader."

Somebody has to care disproportionately or nothing gets organised. That is true, it is unflashy, and it is exactly the trait a client-facing seat runs on.

3 The reframe that makes it serious

Right now your story sounds like finding somewhere to live. Here is the sentence that changes what it is.

THE THING YOU HAVE NOT SAID

A standard UK student joint tenancy makes all tenants **jointly and severally liable**. In plain English: if one housemate stops paying, **the others are legally liable for their share**. The landlord can pursue any one of you for the whole rent.

So what you were actually doing was getting **six people, four of whom you had never met, to enter a contract that made each of you financially liable for all of the others.**

That is not a house hunt. That is a commitment problem with real money attached, and most people your age do not know this is how it works.

CHECK THIS BEFORE YOU USE IT

Some student lets use **individual room contracts** instead, where each person is only liable for their own room. If yours was individual contracts, the liability point does not hold and you must not claim it. **Look at your tenancy agreement.** If it is one agreement with all six names on it, you are almost certainly jointly and severally liable and the framing is yours to use.

4 The economics you can name — and this is your edge

You are an economics student. What you lived through has a name, and almost no candidate will use it.

It was a **free-rider problem.** Everyone wanted the outcome. Nobody individually bore a cost from not acting — because each person could rationally assume somebody else would do it.

That is not a complaint about your housemates. It is a correct description of their incentives, and framing it that way does two useful things at once: it shows you can analyse a situation rather than just resent it, and it is generous to them, which always reads better than being critical.

The classic version is the collective action problem: a group all benefit from something, the effort is individually costly, so the rational individual move is to wait. **With six people it is worse than with two, because each person's share of the blame is smaller.** You can say that in one sentence and it lands hard.

WHY THIS IS BETTER THAN IT SOUNDS

Compare two reflections on identical facts:

Weak: "They weren't pulling their weight, so I had to step up."

Strong: "It was a free-rider problem. Nobody was being lazy exactly — each of them could rationally assume someone else would sort it, and with six people everybody's share of the blame is small enough that waiting is the sensible individual move."

Same facts. The second one sounds like somebody who understands people rather than somebody who was annoyed by them.

5 The pragmatic trade-off — the Sam move

The framework says the reflection must defend a trade-off that was not the textbook answer. Here is yours, and I think you made it without realising.

THE TEXTBOOK ANSWER

Divide the work six ways. Have an honest conversation about everyone pulling their weight. Hold people to their tasks.

Why it was never going to work: six people in different cities, four of whom had never met you, no authority, a deadline you did not control, and nothing you could do if they ignored you.

WHAT YOU ACTUALLY DID

You stopped trying to get equal participation. You took on **the work anyone could have done**, so that the only thing left for each of them was **the thing nobody could do on their behalf** — agreeing, signing and paying.

Not an equal split. But it was the only version that finished before the good houses went.

The lesson, and it is genuinely transferable: **when you cannot control whether people engage, you can still control how small you make the thing you need from them.**

That sentence is the best thing in your answer. It is a real operating principle, you earned it, and it applies directly to a job where you will be coordinating twenty internal teams who do not report to you.

"But is that actually teamwork, if I did it all?"

You asked this and you were right to. It is the obvious objection and the answer has to be precise, because *"I absorbed the work"* can easily read as **working alone while five people watched** — which is martyrdom, not teamwork, and a reviewer would be entitled to mark it down.

The fix is not a different story. It is being exact about what the team's task actually was.

> The task was never "find a house." Anyone can ring a letting agent. The task was **six people arriving at one binding joint decision** — and you cannot sign a joint tenancy alone.

Split the work into two kinds and the objection dissolves:

Kind of work	Examples here	Who could do it
Fungible	Ringing agents, booking viewings, setting up the group chat, chasing people	**Anyone.** It does not matter whose name is on it. This is the part you took.
Non-fungible	Agreeing to the house. Signing the tenancy. Sending the deposit.	**Only that specific person.** You could not do this for anybody, and all six had to deliver it.

So you did not do the team's work. **You cleared the fungible work off the critical path so the only thing left on it was the work that genuinely required six people.** That is task design, not substitution.

> YOU ALREADY SAID THE PROOF YOURSELF
>
> "So ultimately they can send me the money." **Six people sent money.** A deposit leaving someone's account is a real commitment, not a vague agreement. Every single member of that team delivered the irreplaceable thing. Say that and the objection is answered before it is raised.

Put the team back in the answer

One genuine weakness in the first draft of your story: the other five are almost invisible in it. Three additions, all true, all cheap:

1. **Credit the one you knew.** A stranger organising your tenancy is a hard sell — somebody must have given you credibility with the other four. Did he vouch for you? View anything? Chase people you could not reach? If so, say it. Crediting a named person without performing humility is one of the markers of a strong teamwork answer.
2. **Say they came through.** "To be fair to them, when it came to it everyone signed and everyone paid on time." It stops you sounding bitter, and it is true.
3. **Name the trust running the other way.** Four people who had never met you agreed to be *jointly liable alongside you*. They took a risk on you as much as you took one on them. Almost nobody thinks to say this, and it reframes the whole story from "I carried them" to "we all committed to each other."

ONE QUESTION THAT COULD MAKE THIS MUCH STRONGER — ANSWER IT HONESTLY

When people stopped replying in the group chat, **did you start messaging them individually?**

If you did, say it, because it is a real and slightly counterintuitive insight: *a group chat is where accountability goes to die.* Ask six people something in a group and nobody answers, because each one assumes another will. Ask one person directly and they answer, because now it is visibly theirs.

That detail is specific, true, and almost nobody would think to say it. But only use it if it is what you did.

6 The number you need — go and find one

The framework is firm about this: the Result must be hard and quantifiable. Right now yours is "we got the house," which is binary and weak. **I do not know your numbers, so here are the candidates. Pick the one that is true.**

Possible number	How strong, and how to check
When you signed, versus when other groups were still looking	**Best, if you know it.** "We signed in November; people I know were still looking in February." Timing proves the deadline mattered and that you beat it. Check your tenancy start date and when you signed.
Number of properties you arranged viewings for	Strong and concrete. "I arranged viewings on eleven properties from London." Check your emails to the agents.
Six people, four of whom you had never met	Already quantified, already striking, and you definitely know it. Use this one regardless.
115 miles	Free specificity. Use it in the Situation.
Rent per person versus what others paid	Only if you genuinely know it and you came out well. Do not guess.
How long the whole thing took	Weak on its own, decent alongside another. "Three weeks from setting up the group chat to signing."

Minimum bar: two real numbers in the answer. "Six people, four I'd never met" is one — you have it already. Go and find the second from your emails or your tenancy agreement before you film. It will take ten minutes and it is the difference between a 3 and a 4.

7 The full answer, in STAR-R

About 110 seconds. Square brackets are where your real numbers go. Highlighted phrases are doing specific work — keep the function, change the words.

SITUATION — ~20 SECONDS

So this was during my placement year. Six of us were trying to get a house together for final year in Norwich, and the complication was that I'd only actually met one of the five. The other four were his friends and I'd never met them. I was also living in London at the time, so I was organising a house I couldn't see, about a hundred and fifteen miles away. And Norwich student housing goes in quite a narrow window — if you're slow you end up with whatever's left.

TASK — ~15 SECONDS

So the job was getting six people who mostly didn't know each other to commit to a joint tenancy before the decent stock went. And a joint tenancy means you're all liable for each other's rent, so it's a reasonably big thing to ask people to sign, especially strangers.

ACTION — ~45 SECONDS

First thing I did was just make a group chat, because there wasn't one — six people and no shared way of talking to each other. Then I made myself the single point of contact with the letting agents, because agents want one name rather than six, and I booked [number] viewings. [If true: and the one person I did know vouched for me with the others, which mattered more than it sounds — I was a stranger asking four people to sign something with me.]

The problem was nobody would go, and after a bit people stopped replying in the chat at all. Honestly, my first reaction was that they weren't bothered. But I think it was more that with six people everyone assumes someone else will deal with it — it's basically a free-rider thing, nobody individually loses anything by waiting.

So I stopped trying to split it evenly. I took on the bit that anyone could do — the calls, the viewings, the chasing — so the only thing left for them was the bit only they could do, which was agreeing, signing and sending the deposit. [If true: and I started messaging people individually rather than in the group, because a group chat is where accountability disappears.]

RESULT — ~15 SECONDS

We signed in [month], [comparison — e.g. while people I knew were still looking months later], and that's the house we're in now. Six people housed, four of whom I'd never met when it started. And to be fair to them, when it came to it everyone signed and everyone paid on time.

REFLECTION — ~20 SECONDS

Looking back, the textbook answer would have been to divide it six ways and hold everyone to their bit. That was never realistic with people in different cities who'd never met and a deadline I didn't control. It wasn't an equal split and I wouldn't pretend it was — but it was the only version that finished on time. What I took from it is that when you can't control whether people engage, you can still control how small you make the thing you need from them. And the other thing, which I only really thought about afterwards — four of them agreed to be liable for my rent having never met me. So the trust was going both ways.

8 Weak version versus strong version

Same events. Read both aloud.

WHAT MOST PEOPLE WOULD SAY

"During my placement year I worked with a team of five other students to find accommodation for our final year. I took on a leadership role and set up a group chat to improve our communication."

"Some team members were less engaged than others, so I motivated them to participate and encouraged everyone to contribute."

"I liaised with letting agents and organised viewings. Through effective teamwork and communication we successfully secured a property."

"This taught me the importance of communication and taking initiative in a team environment."

YOURS, PROPERLY TOLD

"Six of us, and I'd only met one of them. I was in London, the house was in Norwich, 115 miles away, and Norwich housing goes in a narrow window."

"A joint tenancy makes you all liable for each other's rent — so I was asking four strangers to sign something quite serious."

"Nobody would view, and people stopped replying. I thought they weren't bothered. Actually it's a free-rider thing — with six people, waiting is the rational move."

"So I took on the bit anyone could do, so the only thing left for them was the bit only they could do — sign, and send the deposit."

"Not an equal split, and I wouldn't pretend it was. But when you can't control whether people engage, you can control how small you make the ask."

"And to be fair to them, everyone signed and everyone paid. Four of them agreed to be liable for my rent having never met me — the trust went both ways."

What changed	Why it matters
Stakes named	Joint liability turns a house hunt into a commitment problem with money attached.
Constraint made concrete	115 miles, four strangers, a window you don't control. Specific beats abstract.
No claim to have reformed anyone	The weak version says "I motivated them." Nobody believes that. The strong version explains their behaviour instead of fixing it.
A named concept	"Free-rider problem" is your discipline doing work on a real situation.
A defended trade-off	"Not an equal split and I wouldn't pretend it was" is the sentence that makes you sound honest rather than polished.
A transferable lesson	"Control how small you make the ask" beats "I learned the importance of communication" by a mile.

9 What to cut

Cut	Because
"I took on a leadership role"	You did not have one. Describe what you did and let them conclude it.
"I motivated them and they started contributing"	The framework is explicit: nobody believes you transformed anyone in a fortnight. And it is not what happened.
"Through effective teamwork and communication"	Filler. Also slightly false — the whole point is that communication largely failed and you worked around it.
"The team decided" / "we agreed"	Passive. You did it. Say "I".
"This taught me the importance of initiative"	The most generic sentence available. Your real lesson is far better.
Any criticism of your housemates	Never complain about the people in your story. The free-rider framing lets you describe exactly the same behaviour while sounding analytical rather than bitter. **You will live with these people until next summer, too.**
Apologising for the story being small	Do not say "it's not a big thing but". It signals you do not rate your own answer, and the reviewer will agree with you.
"I absorbed all the work" / "I ended up doing everything"	**The most important cut.** It makes a teamwork answer into a working-alone answer. Say "I took on the bit anyone could do, so the only thing left for them was the bit only they could do." Same action, and it is the accurate description.

10 Follow-ups

They ask	You say
"Wasn't that just you doing everything?"	The fair question, so meet it head on. "Pretty much, yes. I'd defend it on the deadline — there wasn't time to build a working split with people I'd never met. If it had been a year rather than a few weeks, I'd have done it differently."
"Weren't you annoyed with them?"	"At the time a bit, honestly. Afterwards less so — I don't think anyone was being difficult, it's just what happens when six people share responsibility for one thing."
"What would you do differently?"	"Set it up at day zero. One named person per task before anyone cares yet, rather than trying to assign work once it's already urgent and people have switched off."
"Is that really teamwork, if you did it alone?"	**The challenge to have word-perfect.** "I'd say teamwork is six people getting to one decision together, not six people doing equal amounts of admin. Every one of them had to actually sign and actually pay, and I couldn't do that bit for anyone. What I could do was make sure that was the *only* thing they had to do." That wins the challenge rather than deflecting it.
"Give me another example."	Have one ready. Your DDQ portal is the same shape — coordinating twenty internal teams you had no authority over. Say so: "Same trait, honestly, in a work setting."

11 Why this story is better for this job than you think

> Client Solutions Group is a seat where you coordinate investment teams, legal, compliance and operations — **none of whom report to you** — to get something to a client by a date you do not control.

Read that back, then read your story again. It is the same problem. No authority, people with other priorities, a deadline set elsewhere, and a result that depends entirely on how well you reduce friction for people who are not that invested.

And notice something: **the same trait shows up in your DDQ portal** — 400 lines, 20 teams, none of whom worked for you. That makes it a *pattern* rather than an anecdote, which is far stronger evidence. Do not use both in the same recording, but know that they rhyme, because if a human asks for a second example in round two you have one that proves the first was not a fluke.

BEFORE YOU FILM

- **Check your tenancy agreement.** One agreement with six names means joint and several liability and you can use that framing. Individual room contracts means you cannot.
- **Find your second number.** Search your emails for when you first contacted the agents and when you signed. Ten minutes.
- **Decide honestly** whether you messaged people individually. Only use that detail if you did.
- **Work out what the friend you knew actually contributed.** Did he vouch for you with the other four, view anything, chase people you couldn't reach? If he did, credit him by role. A teamwork answer with one other named human in it beats one with none.
- **Say the free-rider line out loud** a few times until it sounds like a thought rather than a term you looked up.
- **Film it twelve times,** changing the words, keeping the five STAR-R beats and the two numbers fixed.

A note on what is mine and what is yours. Every fact in this answer is yours — I have added no events. What I have added is framing: the joint and several liability point, the free-rider naming, the "shrink the ask" lesson, and the 115-mile figure. The liability point is standard for UK joint tenancies but you must confirm it applies to your contract. The individual-messaging detail and all numbers in square brackets are things only you can supply, and you must not say any of them unless they are true.